

# PAD201: Introduction to Public Administration



Spring 2022 | North South University

Instructor: Ashraf Haque | Email: [mohammad.haque09@northsouth.edu](mailto:mohammad.haque09@northsouth.edu) | Office Hours: By appointment

Section 4: Thursday & Saturday 8:00 AM    Section 5: Thursday & Saturday 9:40 AM

## Course Description

Why do we need government, even when it disappoints us, even when it seems to get in the way? That question is the engine of this course. Public administration is not merely a set of management techniques. It is the institutional machinery through which societies attempt to solve problems that individuals and markets cannot solve alone. Understanding how that machinery works, why it sometimes fails, and how it might be improved is one of the most consequential things a student of social science can learn.

This course introduces the foundational concepts, theories, and debates of public administration. We begin with the question of public purpose: why government institutions exist and what civic and human needs they are meant to serve. We then examine how organizations work, how bureaucracies behave in practice, how accountability is designed and often undermined, and how reform efforts succeed or stumble. Throughout, students apply theory to real problems, argue across competing frameworks, and develop the professional skills, covering analytical, written, and oral skills, that any effective manager requires in any sector: government, nonprofit, and for-profit.

By the end of this course, you will not simply know more about government. You will be able to identify and analyze a governance problem or debate, and identify the competing assumptions beneath it, to design a solution and defend it under pressure. You will also recognize, with some precision, when an institution is failing and why.

## Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- **Explain public purpose:** articulate why government institutions exist, what collective problems they are designed to solve, and why those problems resist purely private solutions.
- **Apply organizational theory:** use classical, behavioral, and institutional theories to analyze how public organizations are structured, how bureaucrats make decisions, and how organizational culture shapes outcomes.
- **Diagnose policy problems:** identify market failures, government failures, and implementation breakdowns, and evaluate the tradeoffs among competing policy responses.
- **Construct and defend arguments:** develop evidence-based policy positions, anticipate and respond to counterarguments, and communicate recommendations clearly to non-specialist audiences.
- **Produce professional work:** write a policy memo that meets professional standards of clarity, precision, and persuasion, and present findings orally to a critical audience.
- **Engage across difference:** work productively with diverse peers, recognize how context shapes institutional behavior, and apply theory critically.

## Teaching Approach

This course will not reward passive attendance. It will reward engagement with ideas, with well-articulated arguments, with your peers, and with the real discomfort of defending a position under pressure. Lecture segments are deliberately short. The majority of your learning will happen in discussions, case analyses, teamwork, and debate. I will circulate, question, and push back. So will your classmates.

I also believe that diverse perspectives are not a courtesy. They are an analytical asset. The problems we study look different depending on where you sit. A student who grew up navigating a weak-capacity bureaucracy in rural areas and a student whose frame of reference is the most elite neighborhood in Dhaka

will see the same theory differently. Both perspectives sharpen the analysis. I will consistently ask: does this theory apply? Where does it break down? What does it miss?

## **Signature Assignments**

### **Assignment 1: Policy Memo (Team Project) — 25% of Final Grade**

The policy memo is the centerpiece of this course. It asks you to do what a public administrator actually does: identify a problem, analyze it through competing theoretical lenses, and recommend a solution you can defend.

#### **The Task**

Your team will be assigned a collective action problem, a situation in which individually rational behavior produces a collectively bad outcome, or in which a public good is undersupplied because no private actor has sufficient incentive to provide it. Examples include: urban traffic congestion, vaccine hesitancy, groundwater depletion, public park maintenance, or police accountability.

Your memo must do four things: (1) define the problem precisely, including who bears its costs and why markets or voluntary action have failed to solve it; (2) analyze the problem using at least two theoretical frameworks from the course; (3) propose a specific policy intervention, either government-based, market-based, or hybrid, with a clear rationale; and (4) anticipate and address the strongest objection to your recommendation.

#### **Format and Length**

The memo should be 1,000–1,200 words, written in the style of a professional policy document, concise, direct, and free of academic jargon. It should be addressed to a specific decision-maker (a minister, agency head, or city council). Include a one-paragraph executive summary at the top. Use headings. Cite your sources.

#### **Process**

Teams are assigned in Week 1 and remain together for the full semester. In Week 6, you will receive your problem. In Week 11, you will submit a one-page outline for instructor feedback before the full memo is due. The memo is due at the end of Week 12. Written feedback will be returned within one week. Your team will then present and defend your memo's findings in Week 14.

#### **Evaluation Criteria**

- Problem definition: Is the collective action problem identified precisely? Is the market or voluntary failure diagnosed correctly?
- Theoretical reasoning: Are course frameworks applied accurately and insightfully, not just mentioned?
- Quality of recommendation: Is the proposed intervention specific, feasible, and logically connected to the diagnosis?
- Anticipation of objections: Does the memo engage seriously with the strongest counterargument?
- Professional communication: Is the memo clear, well-organized, and appropriate for its intended audience?

## Assignment 2: Team Debate and Presentation — 20% of Final Grade

The debate is designed to make you do something harder than writing a good argument: defending it in real time against a team that has thought carefully about why you are wrong.

### The Task

Each team will defend a position on their policy problem from a specific theoretical perspective assigned by the instructor. You may not agree with the position you are assigned. That is intentional. Understanding a framework well enough to argue from it, even when you are skeptical of it, is one of the most valuable analytical skills this course can develop.

The debate follows a structured format: opening statement (3 minutes per team), direct rebuttal (2 minutes), open floor questioning from classmates (5 minutes), and closing statement (2 minutes). The instructor will then debrief the theoretical assumptions that drove each position.

### Presentation

In Week 14, each team presents its policy memo findings publicly (13–15 minutes). This is not a reading of the memo. It is a presentation designed for an audience that has not read your document. You should explain your problem, your recommendation, and your reasoning, and then take questions. Questions will come from classmates and from the instructor. You are evaluated not only on the quality of your argument but on how you respond under questioning.

### Evaluation Criteria

- Argumentation: Is the position argued clearly and with logical coherence?
- Use of evidence: Are claims supported with specific evidence from readings, cases, or data?
- Responsiveness: Does the team engage seriously with counterarguments rather than deflecting them?
- Theoretical grounding: Is the assigned theoretical lens applied accurately and consistently?
- Clarity of presentation: Is the argument accessible to a non-specialist audience?

### Course Materials

There is no required textbook. Lecture handouts (5–6 pages each) summarizing essential concepts will be posted before each class. All required readings, articles, book chapters, and official reports, are available on the course website. Students should complete the readings before class to engage fully in discussions and case analyses. Readings are selected to span different theoretical traditions and different national contexts; part of the analytical work of this course is asking how ideas travel across those contexts.

### Assessment and Grading

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| Assessment | Weight | What Is Being Evaluated |
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|----------------------------|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation              | 10% | Quality of in-class contributions, willingness to engage competing ideas, and respectful engagement with peers across discussions and debates.                                                    |
| Quiz 1 & Quiz 2            | 10% | Low-stakes retrieval of core concepts and vocabulary. Each quiz is worth 5%. No makeup quizzes without prior notice.                                                                              |
| Midterm Exam               | 15% | Short analytical notes testing conceptual understanding of Units 1–3. No fill-in-the-blank or true/false — answers must be argued, not recalled.                                                  |
| Policy Memo (Team Project) | 25% | Written analysis of a collective action problem with a justified policy recommendation. Evaluated on problem definition, theoretical reasoning, evidence quality, and professional communication. |
| Team Debate & Presentation | 20% | Oral defense of a policy position using competing theoretical lenses. Evaluated on argumentation, use of evidence, responsiveness to counterarguments, and clarity.                               |
| Final Exam                 | 15% | Two open-note analytical response questions applying course theory to a novel public administration problem not seen in class. Recall alone cannot answer these questions.                        |
| Attendance                 | 5%  | Regular, punctual attendance. More than two unexcused absences will reduce this score. Attendance credit cannot be made up.                                                                       |

Grading follows NSU’s standard grading policy. Final grades reflect cumulative performance across all components. There is no extra credit. Late submissions will be penalized 10% per day unless an extension is requested at least 48 hours in advance. You will find the standard grading policy here: <http://www.northsouth.edu/academic/grading-policy.html>

## Course Schedule

| Week                                                                             | Lecture | Topic & Activities                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Assessment / Milestone                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| <b>UNIT 1 — Why Government? Public Purpose and Collective Action (Weeks 1–2)</b> |         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                              |
| 1                                                                                | 1       | Course introduction. Central provocation: why do we need government even when it disappoints us? Concept of public goods and collective action failures. Open discussion, no lecture handout, no slides. Students speak first. | <b>Teams assigned (4–5 students, random)</b> |

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|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2                                                                              | 2  | Public vs. private sector: similarities, differences, and why the distinction matters for management and accountability. In-class case: a real public goods failure students recognize from everyday life. Teams discuss and report back.        | <b>Quiz 1 (end of Week 2) — covers Lectures 1–2 vocabulary</b>                                   |
| <b>UNIT 2 — How Organizations Work: Theory and Behavior (Weeks 3–6)</b>        |    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                  |
| 3                                                                              | 3  | Classical organization theory: Taylor, Fayol, Gulick (POSDCORB). What assumptions do these theorists make about human behavior? Are they realistic?                                                                                              |                                                                                                  |
| 3                                                                              | 4  | Weber on bureaucracy: rationality, hierarchy, rules. In-class exercise: map a familiar government agency onto Weber's ideal type. Where does it fit? Where does it break down?                                                                   |                                                                                                  |
| 4                                                                              | 5  | Simon and bounded rationality: the behavioral turn in organization theory. Short case: how would Taylor vs. Simon approach the same management decision? Teams compare answers.                                                                  |                                                                                                  |
| 5                                                                              | 6  | Human Relations movement: Mayo, Hawthorne studies, motivation theories. What does this tradition add that classical theory misses?                                                                                                               |                                                                                                  |
| 6                                                                              | 7  | Organizational behavior synthesis: leadership, group dynamics, decision-making under uncertainty. TEAM PROJECT ASSIGNED. Teams receive their collective action problem. Half the session used for team working time with instructor circulation. | <b>Team Project assigned — problem distributed, teams begin scoping</b>                          |
| <b>UNIT 3 — Bureaucracy in Practice: Accountability and Reform (Weeks 7–9)</b> |    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                  |
| 7                                                                              | 8  | Bureaucracy in practice: Wilson on what agencies actually do and why. The problem of red tape: when does procedure protect and when does it obstruct?                                                                                            |                                                                                                  |
| 8                                                                              | 9  | New Public Management as a response: Osborne and Gaebler, reinvention, privatization. Case: a real NPM reform — what worked, what did not, and why?                                                                                              |                                                                                                  |
| 9                                                                              | 10 | Ethics and public service values: public service motivation, accountability, and the limits of efficiency as a goal. Denhardt and Denhardt on the New Public Service.                                                                            | <b>MIDTERM EXAM (end of Week 9). Short analytical notes only — no MCQ, no fill-in-the-blank.</b> |

| UNIT 4 — Politics, Power, and Institutional Design (Weeks 10–12) |    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10                                                               | 11 | Politics-administration dichotomy: Wilson’s original argument and contemporary critiques. Is the separation of politics and administration possible — or desirable? Students read both sides before class.                              |                                                                                                        |
| 11                                                               | 12 | Centralization vs. decentralization and local government. Case: a decentralization reform from a developing country. Did proximity to citizens improve service delivery?                                                                | <b>Teams submit one-page policy memo outline for instructor feedback</b>                               |
| 12                                                               | 13 | Development administration and governance in low-income contexts — Riggs on developing country bureaucracies. How do structural constraints shape administrative capacity? In-class discussion: how does theory travel across contexts? | <b>POLICY MEMO DUE (end of Week 12). Written feedback returned within one week.</b>                    |
| UNIT 5 — Application, Debate, and Synthesis (Weeks 13–15)        |    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                        |
| 13                                                               | 14 | STRUCTURED DEBATE. Teams defend assigned positions on their collective action problem using competing theoretical lenses. Instructor facilitates, does not adjudicate. Class votes on most persuasive argument — with reasons.          | <b>Quiz 2 (after debate session) — one application question included</b>                               |
| 14                                                               | 15 | TEAM PRESENTATIONS. Each team presents policy memo findings publicly (13–15 minutes). Open questions from class and instructor. Evaluated on argumentation, evidence, and responsiveness under questioning.                             |                                                                                                        |
| 15                                                               | 16 | Synthesis and reflection. What theoretical lenses did teams use? What did the debates reveal about competing assumptions? Course debrief: what can you now do, argue, and decide that you could not in Week 1?                          | <b>FINAL EXAM (take-home, 48 hours). Two analytical response questions — novel problem, open note.</b> |

## Required Readings

The following readings are assigned across the course schedule. Full citations and access links are posted on the course website.

## Unit 1: Public Purpose and Collective Action

- Thomas R. Dye (2013). *Understanding Public Policy*, Ch. 2: market failure and the rationale for government intervention.
- Elinor Ostrom (1990). *Governing the Commons*, Ch. 1: when communities solve collective action problems without government.

## **Unit 2: Organizational Theory**

- Frederick W. Taylor (1911). *The Principles of Scientific Management*, Ch. 1.
- L. Gulick & L. Urwick (1937). *Notes on the Theory of Organization* (POSDCORB).
- Max Weber (1946). 'Bureaucracy' from *Economy and Society*.
- Herbert A. Simon (1947). *Administrative Behavior*, Ch. 1.
- Elton Mayo (1930). 'The Hawthorne Experiments,' *Human Relations*, 3(2): 3–32.

## **Unit 3: Bureaucracy, Accountability, and Reform**

- James Q. Wilson (1989). *Bureaucracy: What Government Agencies Do and Why They Do It*, Ch. 1.
- David Osborne & Ted Gaebler (1992). *Reinventing Government*, Introduction.
- Janet V. Denhardt & Robert B. Denhardt (2003). 'The New Public Service,' *Public Administration Review*, 60(6): 549–59.
- James S. Bowman & Jonathan P. West (2018). *Public Service Ethics*, Ch. 4.

## **Units 4 & 5: Politics, Institutional Design, and Development**

- Woodrow Wilson (1887). *The Study of Administration*, *Political Science Quarterly*, 2(2): 197–222.
- Anwar Shah (2007). *Local Governance in Developing Countries*, Ch. 4.
- Fred W. Riggs (1961). *Development Administration*, Ch. 1.
- Sendhil Mullainathan & Eldar Shafir (2013). *Scarcity: Why Having Too Little Means So Much*, Ch. 1: cognitive load, poverty, and institutional behavior.

## **Course Policies**

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### **Academic Integrity**

All work submitted must be your own. Plagiarism and unauthorized collaboration are violations of the university's academic integrity policy and will be reported. You are responsible for every sentence in your submission.

### **Attendance and Participation**



Regular attendance is expected. More than two unexcused absences will reduce your participation grade. If you must miss a class, notify the instructor in advance. Participation credit reflects the quality of your contributions, not their quantity — one incisive comment is worth more than three that restate the obvious.

### **Inclusivity and Respect**

This course regularly engages questions about government, policy, and institutions that carry political and cultural weight. Students are expected to engage ideas seriously, challenge arguments with evidence, and treat peers with consistent respect — including when they disagree strongly. Diverse viewpoints, including those grounded in different national experiences, strengthen the analysis. They are not a courtesy; they are the material.

### **Communication**

Course materials and announcements are posted on the course website. Check email and the site regularly. For questions about course content or assignments, use office hours or email. I respond to emails within 48 hours on weekdays.